

Testing the Arm 3 text messages — step by step

A hands-on walkthrough: create a participant, set the dates, get real texts · 15 September 2026

What this covers. Three text messages that Arm 3 participants really receive, all built and working today: the **phone-confirmation passcode**, the **1-week session reminder**, and the **3-month booster reminder**. You will create one test participant and receive all three on your own phone.

Time needed: about 25 minutes, most of it typing the participant's details once.

What you need: a REDCap login with rights to add records, and your mobile phone.

Not covered: the weekly 12-week message series. That one is not built yet and is waiting on two decisions from you — see the separate weekly-SMS document.

Real texts, to a real phone, costing real money. The study's texting account is live. Every message in this manual will actually arrive on the number you enter. Use your own mobile, and don't put a participant's number in a test record.

Never reply STOP to test opting out. The phone company blocks your handset for the study permanently until you text START back, which would end your ability to test anything. Section 6 shows the safe way to test opt-out.

0 Before you start — ask your coordinator to confirm three things

These are one-time setup items. If any is missing, no text can send no matter what you do, and you would be left guessing why. A five-minute check now saves an hour.

NEEDS TO BE TRUE	WHERE
The 21 study alerts exist in this project	Project Setup → Alerts & Notifications. You should see a numbered list starting “01 Phone check”. If the list is empty they have not been imported into this project yet — that has to happen first.
Texting is switched on for alerts, not just surveys	The Twilio setting must be “ Surveys and Alerts ”. If it is “Surveys only”, every alert in this manual is silently undeliverable.
The phone field is validated as a phone number	<code>phonen</code> must have validation Phone . Without it REDCap refuses to use it as a text recipient.

Then: switch on one alert at a time

In **Alerts & Notifications**, leave everything deactivated and enable only the alert each test names. This is the single most useful habit in this whole manual: if five alerts are live at once and a text arrives, you cannot tell which one sent it.

1 Create your test participant in Arm 3

1. Go to **Add / Edit Records**.
2. Choose the arm first. In the arm dropdown pick **Arm 3: MICA + Weekly SMS**. This matters — Arm 3 is the only arm with the weekly-SMS schedule, and two of the three alerts below check which arm the participant is in before sending.
3. Click **Add new record**. Note the record number you get; you will need it.
4. Open the **Day 1 (ED)** event. Everything in sections 2–4 happens here.

Why pick the arm by hand rather than letting `study_group` do it: the module can place a record into its randomized arm automatically, but choosing Arm 3 up front is one click and removes any doubt about where the record landed. You will still set `study_group = 3` in the next section, because that is the field the study's reports and message text read.

2 Fill in the **admin** instrument — the four fields that control texting

Open the **admin** instrument at Day 1 (ED). These four fields are what make the difference between “no text ever arrives” and “the right text arrives at the right time”.

FIELD	WHAT TO ENTER	WHY IT MATTERS
<code>randomization_date</code>	See section 3 — the date depends on which test you are running. Get this right on your first save.	Every timed reminder counts days from this date. It is the clock for the whole study.
<code>study_group</code>	3 — MICA + Weekly SMS	Records the allocation. Message text pipes this in, so a wrong value shows up in the text the participant reads.
<code>sms_stop</code>	Leave unticked	Ticking it suppresses every text. Section 6 uses this deliberately.
<code>study_withdrawn</code>	Leave unticked	Same — withdrawn participants get nothing.

Set the instrument status to **Complete** and save.

The one mistake that wastes a whole test run. REDCap works out when a reminder is due the *first* time you save a date into `randomization_date`, and then never recalculates it. If you save today's date and afterwards go back and change it to a date in the past, the reminder keeps its original schedule and **nothing will arrive** — with no error to tell you why.

So: **type the backdated date on your very first save of this form.** If you get it wrong, don't try to correct it — go back to section 1 and create a fresh record. That is genuinely faster than unpicking it.

3 Which date to enter

Rather than waiting three months for a reminder, you set the randomization date in the past so the reminder is already due. Pick the row for the test you want and count back from today.

TEST	ENTER AS randomization_date	WHICH TEXT ARRIVES
Section 4 — passcode	Today's date (any date works)	Passcode text, immediately
Section 5 — 1-week session reminder	Today minus 7 days	Session reminder, within about 90 seconds
Section 7 — 3-month booster reminder	Today minus 92 days	Booster reminder, within about 90 seconds

You cannot do all three on one record in one sitting, because they want different dates. The simplest approach is one record per test — records are free, and each one keeps its own clean evidence of what happened.

4 Test one — the phone-confirmation passcode

Activate only: “01 Phone check – passcode by SMS” · **Arrives:** within seconds of saving, no waiting · **Sends:** once per record, ever

1. Open the `consent` instrument, fill enough to be plausible, set the status to **Complete**, save.
2. Open the `contact_info` instrument. This is the form that sends the passcode. Fill in:

<code>first_name</code>	your name — it is piped into other messages
<code>phonen</code>	your own mobile number
<code>email</code>	your email address
<code>choice_fup_delivery</code>	tick “SMS to [phonen]”
3. Check the passcode field filled itself in. `calcrnd` should now show a **4-digit** number. If it shows 8 digits, stop and tell the study team — a fix has not been applied to this project.
4. Set the status to **Complete** and save. The text is sent during the save itself.
5. Check your phone.

Pass: a text arrives reading “MICA: your verification passcode is NNNN. Enter it on the Check Code form to confirm this is the right phone number.” — where NNNN is the same 4 digits you just saw in `calcrnd`.
6. Close the loop — this is the actual point of the test. Open the `check_code` instrument, type those 4 digits into `passcode`, save. `calc_code_check` must compute **1**, and the page should show the “code

correct” message rather than the “code wrong” one. The text arriving is only half the requirement; this is the half that proves the phone number is confirmed.

One passcode test per record. This alert deliberately sends only once per participant, so re-saving the form will not produce a second text. To test it again, create a new record.

5 Test two — the 1-week session reminder

Activate only: “03 MICA ED session 1-week reminder (SMS)” · **Arrives:** within about 90 seconds · **Date needed:** `randomization_date` = today minus 7 days

This is the nudge for a participant who was randomized a week ago and still has not done their MICA session. Use a **fresh record** (section 1), with the backdated date on the first save (section 2).

1. On `admin`: `randomization_date` = today minus 7 days, `study_group` = 3. Save.
2. On `contact_info`: `first_name`, `phonen` = your mobile, and tick “SMS to [phonen]”. Save.
3. Leave the `mica_ed_session` instrument alone. The reminder only goes to people who have *not* finished their session — completing it is how the reminder gets cancelled, which is section 8.
4. Wait about 90 seconds and check your phone. REDCap checks for due reminders once a minute, so this is not instant like the passcode.

Pass: a text arrives reading “Hi [your name], it's the MICA Team. Your MICA session is ready (about 20 min): [link] Reply STOP to opt out.”

Then tap the link. It must open the MICA session for *your* record. A link that opens nothing, or someone else's record, is a failure even though the text arrived — so please do tap it.

If nothing arrives after three minutes, the most likely cause is the date order described in section 2. Create a fresh record and enter the backdated date on the first save. The second most likely cause is that “SMS to [phonen]” was not ticked — if you tick *only* email, this alert correctly stays silent and the email version sends instead.

6 Test three — opting out actually stops the texts

Activate only: “03 MICA ED session 1-week reminder (SMS)” · **Expected result:** no text at all

A test where nothing happening is the pass. Worth doing, because it is the protection that matters most to a participant who has asked you to stop.

1. Create a fresh record exactly as in section 5 — backdated date, your mobile, SMS ticked.

2. Before saving `contact_info`, go to `admin` and tick `sms_stop`. Save.

3. Wait two minutes.

Pass: no text arrives. Untick `sms_stop`, save again, wait 90 seconds, and the text should then come through — which proves the silence was caused by the opt-out and not by something else being broken.

Please don't test this by texting STOP. That works, but the phone company then blocks your handset for the study's number until you text START back, and you would not be able to run any further tests. Ticking `sms_stop` is exactly what the alert itself reads, so it is a faithful test.

Worth knowing: if a real participant texts STOP, the phone company stops their texts immediately — but REDCap is never told. Someone has to tick this box by hand. That is a gap we have flagged separately.

7 Test four — the 3-month booster reminder (Arm 3 specific)

Activate only: “11 MICA booster session reminder (SMS, arm 3)” · **Date needed:** `randomization_date` = today minus 92 days

There are separate booster alerts for Arm 2 and Arm 3, and this test also confirms an Arm 3 participant gets the **Arm 3** one rather than Arm 2's.

1. Create a fresh record in Arm 3. On `admin` at Day 1 (ED): `randomization_date` = **today minus 92 days**, `study_group` = 3. Save.

2. On `contact_info` at Day 1 (ED): `first_name`, `phonon`, tick SMS. Save.

3. Now move to the **Month 3** event and open `mica_booster_session`. Save it without completing it — leave the status Incomplete.

This save is not busywork. The booster reminder is attached to the Month 3 event, and REDCap only looks at it when something is saved *there*. Without this step the reminder is never even considered, and you would conclude it was broken.

4. Wait about 90 seconds and check your phone.

Pass: a text arrives reading “Hi [your name], it's the MICA Team. Your 3-month booster session is ready: [link] Reply STOP to opt out.” Tap the link — it must open the **booster** session (not the Day-1 session) for your record.

If you want the second booster nudge as well, repeat with `randomization_date` = today minus **98** days and activate “13 MICA booster session 1-week reminder (SMS, arm 3)” instead.

8 Test five — reminders stop once the participant finishes

Activate: “03 MICA ED session 1-week reminder (SMS)” · **Expected result:** no text

The most important test in this manual. If this one fails, participants who have already finished their session still get chased — which is worse than having no reminders at all.

1. **Create a fresh record** as in section 5 — backdated 7 days, your mobile, SMS ticked.
2. **This time, complete the `mica_ed_session` instrument** — set its status to **Complete** and save.
3. **Wait two minutes.**

Pass: no text arrives. The reminder was due, saw that the session was finished, and cancelled itself.

A detail worth knowing rather than worrying about: the cancellation happens on REDCap's next once-a-minute check, not the instant you save. So there is a window of up to a minute after a participant finishes in which a reminder could still go out. With a one-minute check that is small, but it is not zero.

9 Recording what you found

Please note the record number for each test — that is how we trace any failure back to what actually happened in the database. If a text does not arrive, the two questions we will ask are “**which record?**” and “**what exactly did you type into `randomization_date` , and was it on the first save?**”

TEST	RECORD	TEXT ARRIVED?	LINK WORKED?	NOTES
4 — passcode			n/a	
4 — code accepted (<code>calc_code_check</code> = 1)		n/a	n/a	
5 — 1-week reminder				
6 — opt-out silences it		should be NO	n/a	
7 — booster reminder (arm 3)				
8 — finishing cancels it		should be NO	n/a	

When you are done

Please **deactivate every alert again** in Alerts & Notifications. The study has not gone live, and an alert left switched on will keep acting on any record anyone creates afterwards.

10 If something does not work

WHAT YOU SEE	MOST LIKELY CAUSE
No text at all, on any test	One of the three setup items in section 0 — most often Twilio set to “Surveys only” rather than “Surveys and Alerts”.
Passcode text never arrives	<code>consent</code> or <code>contact_info</code> left at Unverified instead of Complete . The alert checks for Complete specifically.
Passcode is 8 digits, not 4	A formula fix has not been applied to this project. Tell the study team before going further.
Timed reminder never arrives	The date-order trap in section 2. Start a fresh record.
An email arrives instead of a text	Only “Email to [email]” was ticked in <code>choice_fup_delivery</code> . Tick the SMS option.
Booster reminder never arrives	Step 3 of section 7 skipped — something must be saved at the Month 3 event.
A test worked once and never again	Expected for the passcode, which sends once per record. Create a new record.

Anything not on this list, send us the record number and roughly what time you saved — we can see exactly what REDCap decided and why.